

1 Irrigation strategies under contrasting water-storage and rainfall 2 conditions in the North China Plain

3 Linjia Yao^{1,†}, Bin Chen^{2,†}, Hao Feng², Qiang Yu^{2,*}, Gang Zhao^{2,*}

4 ¹ College of Natural Resources and Environment, Northwest A&F University, Yangling 712100, China

5 ² State Key Laboratory of Soil and Water Conservation and Desertification Control, College of Soil and Water
6 Conservation Science and Engineering, Northwest A&F University, Yangling, Shaanxi 712100, China

7 † Linjia Yao and Bin Chen contributed equally to this work and share first authorship.

8 * Corresponding authors: Qiang Yu (yuq@nwafu.edu.cn) and Gang Zhao (gang.zhao@nwafu.edu.cn).

9 Abstract

10 Efficient irrigation allocation is essential for sustaining grain production while limiting water consumption in the
11 North China Plain wheat–maize rotation. How spatial targeting redistributes production losses, and whether
12 regional water-storage information improves rainfall-based irrigation decisions, remain unresolved. Continuous
13 process-based crop simulations compared uniform and targeted allocations under equal irrigation budgets and
14 evaluated annual storage–rainfall strategies against matched rainfall-only controls during 2014–2025. Growth
15 parameters were fitted to multisite observations; water-use parameters were calibrated against Wuqiao treatments in
16 2016–2018 and retrospectively tested in 2019. At a 50% irrigation reduction, targeting retained $0.73 \text{ t ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$
17 more simulated combined dry grain than uniform cuts across 9.87 million rotation hectares, equivalent to 7.22
18 million t yr^{-1} or 4.87% of uniform production. Mean production was lower than under uniform cuts on 37.60% of
19 mapped area, while crop-plus-fallow evapotranspiration increased by 20.76 mm yr^{-1} ($2.05 \text{ km}^3 \text{ yr}^{-1}$). Across nine
20 years with eligible Gravity Recovery and Climate Experiment (GRACE) observations, strategies selected at 95%
21 and 98% grain targets retained 96.27% and 99.63% of conventional production, respectively. The 95% strategy
22 reduced irrigation by 130.72 mm and evapotranspiration by 36.84 mm per rotation. Matched storage–rainfall and
23 rainfall-only strategies selected identical quotas and produced identical outcomes. These conditional results support
24 joint production and consumptive-use constraints and local production safeguards, while showing that additional
25 storage information provides no decision benefit within the tested quota design.

26 Keywords

27 winter wheat–summer maize rotation; irrigation management; crop modeling; GRACE; water availability;
28 consumptive water use

29 **1. Introduction**

30 Irrigation management in the North China Plain connects grain production with groundwater availability across the
31 winter wheat–summer maize rotation (Yang et al., 2022). Wheat grows through a relatively dry season, whereas
32 maize receives more summer rainfall; soil-water reserves link their responses to water supply (Yang et al., 2024).
33 Long-term well-watered observations show that rising grain yield has accompanied increasing actual
34 evapotranspiration (ET), despite comparatively stable reference ET (Zhang et al., 2011). Recent aquifer recovery
35 under water transfers, abstraction management and changing climate further emphasizes the connection between
36 agricultural production and regional water-resource objectives (Long et al., 2025; Xu et al., 2026). Irrigation
37 decisions consequently involve the water delivered to fields, the grain it supports and the water consumed over the
38 complete rotation.

39 The production return from that delivery depends on rainfall and preceding crop management. A sixteen-year
40 experiment in 2003–2018 compared seven wheat–maize irrigation schedules and found diminishing marginal
41 production gains as irrigation increased (Yang et al., 2022). A four-year Wuqiao experiment showed that
42 precipitation conditions influenced the preferred wheat schedule and grain production in the subsequent maize crop
43 (Yang et al., 2024). Water applied to wheat can support its immediate growth and leave a different soil-water
44 reserve for maize. The annual response to an irrigation reduction therefore depends on the sequence of crop
45 demand, rainfall and storage changes across both seasons (Yang et al., 2024; Yang et al., 2022).

46 These temporal dependencies occur within a spatially heterogeneous region. Irrigation requirements vary across the
47 North China Plain and among hydrological years in the broader Huang–Huai–Hai Plain (Ren et al., 2022; Wu et al.,
48 2019). Regional crop-model optimization and irrigation-allocation studies demonstrate how climate, soil and crop
49 responses can inform management choices (Jiang et al., 2016; Xiao et al., 2024). Under a limited regional supply,
50 spatial allocation depends on the additional grain obtained from an additional unit of irrigation. An equal-budget
51 comparison with uniform reductions can quantify the production benefit of retaining water in more responsive
52 systems. That benefit also has a water-accounting and distributional dimension: delivery, ET, return flows and
53 storage change represent different boundaries, and a regional grain gain can coexist with losses at particular
54 locations (Grafton et al., 2018; Perry et al., 2009).

55 Quantifying these trade-offs requires crop responses that connect canopy development, grain formation and soil-
56 water depletion through successive seasons. Applications of APSIM and RZ-SHAW in the North China Plain
57 provide process-based assessments of crop water productivity, field water balance and ET (Chen et al., 2010; Fang
58 et al., 2014). Transpiration formulation is a major source of variation in simulated water use among wheat models
59 (Cammarano et al., 2016). Yield agreement alone therefore provides incomplete evidence about the water cost of
60 production or the production response to additional irrigation. Phenology, canopy, biomass, grain and ET
61 observations constrain complementary processes, while documented irrigation treatments identify their combined
62 response to water supply. Continuous simulation preserves the soil-water carry-over required to compare complete
63 management histories.

64 Spatial allocation determines where a regional irrigation budget is delivered; antecedent environmental information
65 can also determine how large that budget should be in a particular year. Recent rainfall describes water input,
66 whereas GRACE total water storage integrates several terrestrial stores over a regional footprint (Save et al., 2016;
67 Scanlon et al., 2016). The storage indicator can thus describe conditions beyond local rainfall, but additional
68 environmental information has management value only when it changes the selected action or its grain–water
69 outcome. Storage–rainfall strategies require comparison with rainfall-only strategies under common selection
70 criteria and monitoring availability. This comparison separates the physical relevance of a hydrological indicator
71 from its incremental value for the available irrigation choices.

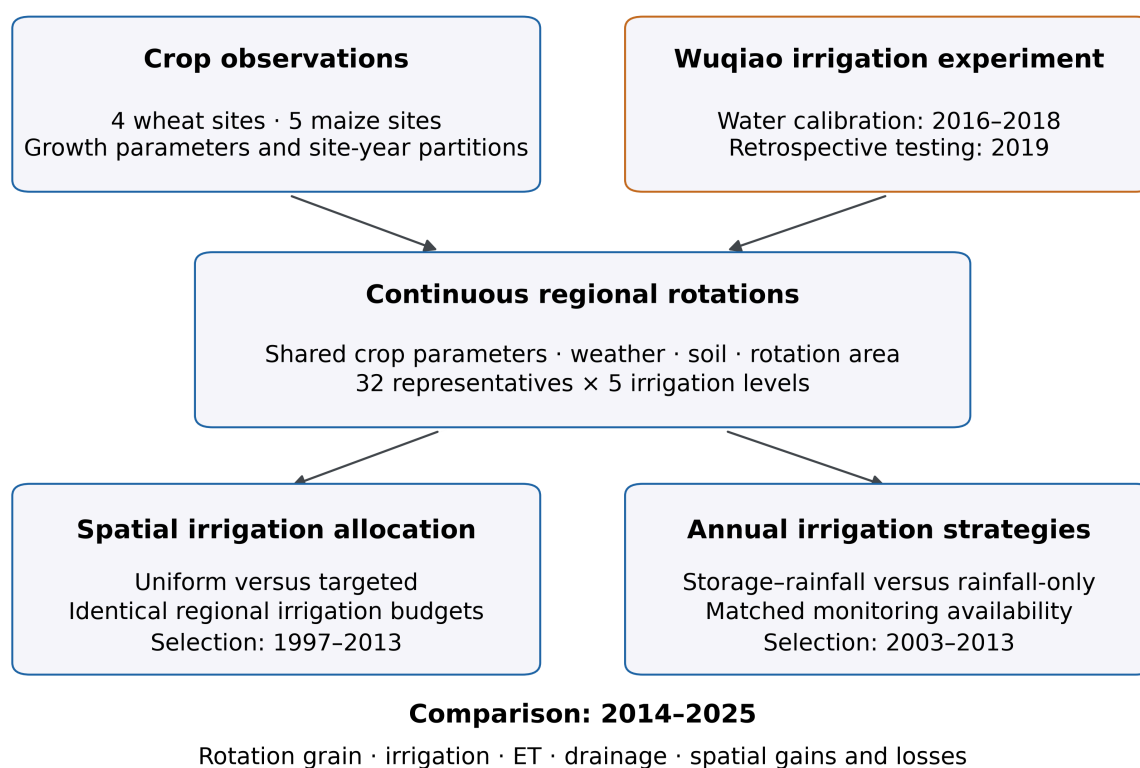
72 Spatial irrigation allocation and antecedent rainfall–storage strategies were compared for the North China Plain
73 wheat–maize rotation using Open Crop Model. Multisite observations supplied crop-growth parameter estimates,
74 and documented Wuqiao treatments in 2016–2018 constrained water-response coefficients. The 2019 field
75 observations provided retrospective testing, while station comparisons characterized transfer under their available
76 management information. Continuous regional simulations compared uniform and targeted allocations under
77 identical irrigation budgets and annual storage–rainfall strategies against matched rainfall-only controls. Production
78 retention, consumptive ET, profile drainage and the spatial and annual distribution of grain changes define the
79 management trade-offs.

80 **2. Materials and methods**

81 **2.1. Overall workflow**

82 The framework connects crop-response estimation with spatial allocation and annual irrigation-quota selection
 83 (Figure 1). Multisite crop observations support growth-parameter estimates, while documented Wuqiao treatments
 84 in 2016–2018 constrain eight water coefficients per crop. Wuqiao 2019 provides retrospective testing; station
 85 observations characterize transfer under the recorded management and initialization. Observation coverage and the
 86 distinct estimation and evaluation partitions are summarized in Figure 3. Daily weather, mapped rotation area and
 87 layered soil profiles define 32 regional representatives.

88 The same crop and water parameters drive continuous crop and fallow histories under five irrigation levels. Spatial
 89 allocations selected from 1997–2013 responses share identical regional delivery budgets with uniform reductions.
 90 Annual storage–rainfall and rainfall-only strategies are selected from matched 2003–2013 responses and compared
 91 with common monitoring availability. Grain production, field irrigation, crop-plus-fallow ET and profile drainage
 92 are evaluated during 2014–2025.



93 **Figure 1. Study workflow.** Multisite observations support growth parameters, while documented Wuqiao treatments calibrate water-
 94 use parameters and provide retrospective testing. Shared parameters drive continuous regional rotations. Spatial allocation
 95 compares uniform and targeted irrigation under identical budgets; annual strategies compare storage–rainfall and rainfall-only
 96 selection under matched monitoring availability. Outcomes cover 2014–2025.

97 2.2. Study area

98 The study area covers the winter-wheat–summer-maize lowlands of the North China Plain within 112–121.5°E and
99 32–41°N, including the Beijing–Tianjin–Hebei sector and the Henan–Anhui–Jiangsu lowlands (Figure 2).
100 Catchment screening, elevation ≤ 200 m and slope $\leq 2^\circ$ define a connected lowland area of 404,658 km². Terrain was
101 represented at 0.01° resolution using resampled SRTM elevation and derived slope (NASA JPL, 2013). The
102 boundary is a reproducible agricultural study-area definition; geographical and terrain-threshold sensitivities are
103 reported in Supplementary Section S3.

104 The 2020 ChinaCP winter-wheat–summer-maize class was corrected by the corresponding CPM cropland
105 percentage to reduce full-pixel area inflation (Qiu et al., 2022). The resulting rotation footprint was 9,866,733 ha
106 before soil exclusions. Three cells with wholly missing soil profiles, totaling 131 ha, were excluded, leaving
107 9,866,602 ha in 3,641 AgERA5 cells. A fixed 2020 footprint applies to all climate years, so modeled totals describe
108 climatic and management responses over a common area rather than historical production trends. The 2015–2021
109 area series, terrain-threshold alternatives and a common-extent comparison with CCD2020 quantify mapping and
110 boundary sensitivity in the supplementary material.

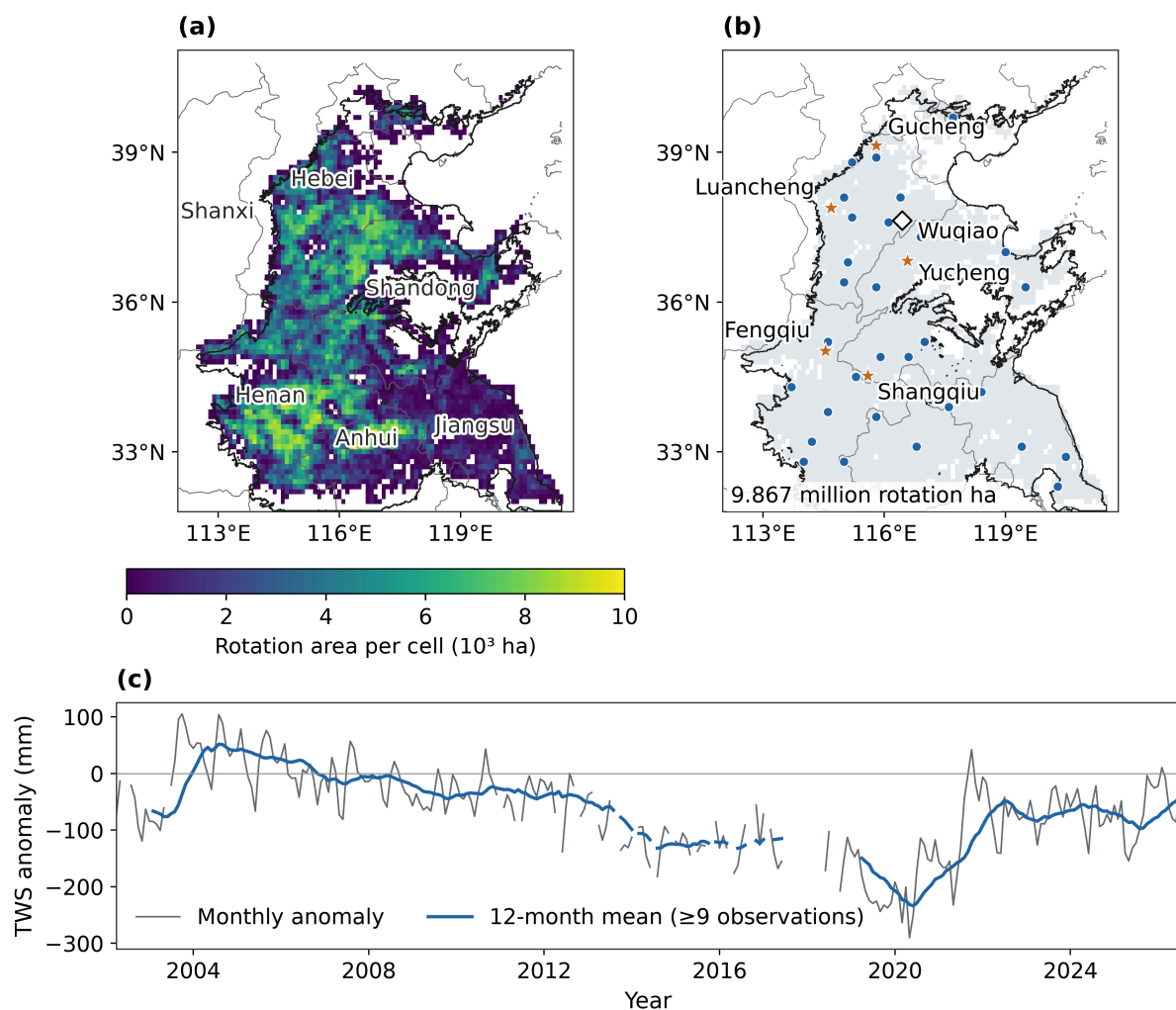


Figure 2. Study domain, rotation area, observation sites and regional water storage. (a) Mapped 2020 wheat–maize rotation area. (b) Five crop-observation sites, the Wuqiao irrigation experiment and 32 regional simulation units. (c) Observed CSR monthly terrestrial-water-storage anomalies and a 12-calendar-month mean requiring at least nine observations. Missing months remain gaps. Thin grey lines show provincial boundaries; black outlines delimit the operational physiographic study domain. Maps use an equirectangular projection (36°N, 117°E). Provincial boundaries: Natural Earth Admin 1 v5.1.1 (Natural Earth, n.d.).

2.3. Field observations and environmental data

2.3.1. Multisite crop observations

Winter-wheat and summer-maize observations were assembled from the National Ecosystem Science Data Center and linked archives at Fengqiu, Gucheng, Luancheng, Shangqiu and Yucheng. The sources contain long-term crop monitoring and the Gucheng maize sowing-date experiment. Archived crop-season groups span 2004–2008 at Fengqiu and Luancheng, 2018–2020 at Gucheng, 2001–2007 at Shangqiu and 1998–2022 at Yucheng. Coverage is intermittent; exact crop-by-site years and dataset identifiers are listed in Tables S1 and S2.

123 The archive retains 132 crop–plot–season trajectories in 71 original calibration and 61 retrospective-evaluation
124 cases (Figure 3). Quality-controlled targets occur in 127 cases. The 7,397 scored records comprise 795 LAI
125 measurements, 543 in-season aboveground-biomass measurements, 5,675 daily ET measurements, 192 grain-yield
126 samples and 192 harvest-biomass samples (Table 1). Daily ET is available at Fengqiu and Yucheng; grain and
127 harvest-biomass samples are confined to Yucheng. Six quadrats within a crop-year characterize sampling variation
128 rather than six independent growing seasons.

129 Observations and predictions share recorded sampling dates or documented averaging windows. Stage-indexed
130 Gucheng LAI measurements use the corresponding observed stage dates as sampling coordinates; those dates do
131 not prescribe simulated development. Fengqiu ET identifies the lysimeter observation plot. Yucheng ET retains the
132 measurement definitions of its source archive. Provider grain and aboveground dry masses in g m^{-2} are multiplied
133 by 10 to obtain kg ha^{-1} .

134 Eligibility requires valid dates, compatible crop and plot identities, consistent stage sequences and documented
135 quantity units. Wheat LAI above $7 \text{ m}^2 \text{ m}^{-2}$ is excluded under the study-specific screening rule, with raw values and
136 reasons preserved. The six-replicate maize harvest vectors in Yucheng 2012 and 2017 are identical despite different
137 dates and cultivar labels. Both groups remain excluded because their source authenticity is unresolved; 12 samples
138 account for 24 grain and harvest-biomass records. Other observations and all eligible sites remain available.

139 Complete irrigation histories matched to station plots remain unconfirmed. Station growth and ET consequently
140 supply conditional transfer comparisons; no station observation enters the current water-parameter objective.
141 Twenty-six Fengqiu cases retain complete 0–1.5 m moisture profiles from the preceding calendar month: 11 in the
142 original calibration partition and 15 in retrospective evaluation. Volumetric percentages from fifteen 100-mm source
143 layers are conservatively remapped to the model layers without depth extrapolation or clipping. Their monthly
144 timing and subplot support do not establish a measured sowing-day state. Cases without an eligible profile retain
145 their archived initialization.

146 **Table 1. Eligible station-observation records by site and variable.**

Site	LAI	Biomass	Daily ET	Yield	Harvest biomass
Fengqiu	159	163	962	0	0
Gucheng	216	0	0	0	0
Luancheng	123	165	0	0	0
Shangqiu	114	148	0	0	0
Yucheng	183	67	4713	192	192

147 Counts denote individual observations, not independent experiments. Station comparisons retain inherited growth-
148 fitting history and unconfirmed complete management. Yucheng grain and harvest biomass contain six dry-matter
149 samples per crop-year; the duplicated 2012 and 2017 maize groups remain excluded.

150 **2.3.2. Field irrigation experiment**

151 The Wujiao experiment at 37.630°N, 116.444°E contains four wheat irrigation schedules, W0–W3, during the
152 2015–2019 rotation (Yang et al., 2024). Dated 75-mm events, sowing and harvest dates, nitrogen input of 158.4 kg
153 ha⁻¹ per crop and treatment-specific initial total water storage in 2 m are retained. Maize irrigation is identical
154 among treatments within each year: zero in 2016 and 2018, and 75 mm on 18 June in 2017 and 2019. Its W0–W3
155 labels therefore identify preceding wheat management. Seasonal initial water distribution among layers is assumed.
156 Field capacity, wilting point and bulk density are transferred from the published Luancheng profile, with its bottom
157 10 cm extrapolated (Sun et al., 2006). Conductivity follows a separate SoilGrids–Saxton–Rawls prior (ISRIC —
158 World Soil Information, 2020; Saxton and Rawls, 2006); the particle-density prior is 2.75 g cm⁻³.

159 Published seasonal ET equals rainfall plus irrigation plus depletion of 0–2 m storage, with runoff and drainage
160 treated as negligible (Yang et al., 2024). The model represents both outflows. The 2016 maize balance uses 499.1
161 mm of maize-season rainfall; the 599.6-mm rotation total also contains 100.5 mm during wheat. This period
162 reconciliation reproduces the four printed maize ET values within 0.9 mm of rounding, and all 32 crop–treatment–
163 season ET targets remain eligible. Simulations retain their exact archived weather forcing. Wheat crop-start storage
164 follows the pre-sowing simulation, whereas maize is independently initialized from observed treatment-specific
165 total storage. Reported wheat-straw mulch has no measured cover fraction, so the maize simulations retain the
166 exposed-soil evaporation boundary (Yang et al., 2024).

167 Harvest aboveground biomass includes grain and residues cut at ground level and oven-dried to constant mass. Its
168 dry-matter basis requires no moisture adjustment. Published grain yields are standardized to 13% moisture (Yang et
169 al., 2024). Annual 2016–2019 means and standard errors are digitized from the source Supplementary Figure S2
170 and reconciled with its eight printed four-year means. Pixel tolerances are approximately 0.043 t ha^{-1} for wheat and
171 0.056 t ha^{-1} for maize. Observed grain is multiplied by 0.87 for dry-matter fitting; model dry grain is divided by
172 0.87 for comparisons reported at 13% moisture. Annual and four-year means overlap and do not provide separate
173 independent observations.

174 The 2016–2018 harvest years contribute 12 treatment seasons per crop to the water fit, with seasonal ET, dry grain,
175 dry aboveground biomass and annual W3–W0 ET contrasts as targets. The four 2019 treatment means per crop are
176 excluded from fitting and parameter selection. Their prior inspection during model development makes this test
177 retrospective (Figure 3).

178 **2.3.3. Meteorological, soil and spatial data**

179 Daily AgERA5 v2.0 weather data for 1996–2025 supplied minimum and maximum air temperature,
180 precipitation, solar radiation, reference evapotranspiration, vapor pressure and 10-m wind speed
181 (Copernicus Climate Change Service, 2020). Reference evapotranspiration (ET_0) entered the water-
182 balance module directly.

183 Native 250 m SoilGrids v2.0 maps of texture, bulk density, organic carbon and coarse fragments were averaged to
184 0.01° , then aggregated over mapped rotation pixels within 0.1° meteorological cells, for six depth intervals between
185 0 and 2 m (ISRIC — World Soil Information, 2020). Hydraulic properties were derived using Saxton–Rawls
186 equations with bulk-density and gravel adjustments (Saxton and Rawls, 2006). Organic matter was approximated
187 using an assumed organic-matter/organic-carbon ratio of 1.724, and air-dry water content was assumed to equal half
188 the wilting-point value. Hydraulic derivation is detailed in Supplementary Section S2.

189 The 2020 ChinaCP wheat–maize class and its CPM cropland fractions defined rotation-area weights (Qiu et al.,
190 2022). SRTM elevation supported the terrain screen and slope calculation (NASA JPL, 2013). Regional aggregation
191 retained the common 0.1° meteorological grid and the study-area definition in Section 2.2.

192 **2.3.4. Terrestrial-water-storage observations**

193 CSR RL06.3 monthly GRACE/GRACE-FO total-water-storage anomalies were aggregated using physical cell
194 areas and the official CSR land mask (Save, 2020; Save et al., 2016). The land-mask overlap covers 395,969 km²
195 within the 404,658-km² study area; excluded coastal supports account for 2.15% of its area. The archive contains
196 259 observed monthly solutions from April 2002 to July 2026 relative to the 2004–2009 mean. Source values in
197 centimeters were converted to millimeters, and missing months remain missing. A 12-calendar-month moving mean
198 requires at least nine observations. The 0.25° product grid is finer than the effective GRACE observation scale, so
199 one regional storage indicator is shared across all simulation units (Save, 2020; Save et al., 2016). Soil, surface and
200 other stores were not subtracted; the indicator represents total water storage rather than groundwater alone.

201 The corresponding aggregation without the CSR land mask is retained as a sensitivity analysis. Regional storage
202 changes provide hydrological context for water-management pressures, with no causal attribution to particular
203 irrigation treatments, water transfers or groundwater regulations (Long et al., 2025; Long et al., 2020).

204 **2.4. Crop model description**

205 Open Crop Model (OCM) couples crop growth and a layered soil-water balance at a daily time step. Wheat
206 development combines temperature, vernalization and photoperiod responses; maize development follows thermal
207 time. Development stage (DVS) is anchored at emergence, flowering and maturity. Germination begins when water
208 above the wilting-point storage is available in the represented layer containing the seed; subsequent thermal
209 development starts from that date. Stage coefficients remain fixed, while the soil-water state can alter establishment
210 timing. Recorded or prescribed harvest dates define the management endpoint separately. Soil-water storage passes
211 continuously through crops and fallows.

212 Canopy interception of radiation follows Beer–Lambert attenuation. Aboveground production depends on
213 intercepted PAR, crop-specific RUE, temperature, prescribed nutrition and an empirical power response to realized
214 transpiration supply. PAR is 0.45 of incident shortwave radiation (Kiniry et al., 1989). Stage-specific SLA
215 determines new leaf area, while established cohorts retain their birth area-to-mass ratio (de Wit and Berghuijs, n.d.).
216 Stage-dependent thermal senescence and a separate daily stress-loss fraction determine leaf survival (Tan et al.,
217 2020). LAI emerges from these carbon and area balances without a maximum-LAI parameter. Simulated biomass at
218 wheat flowering or maize silking determines grain number; fixed individual grain mass defines sink capacity, and
219 assimilate supply and wheat stem reserves constrain grain filling.

220 The water balance represents interception, ponding, infiltration, evaporation, root uptake, runoff and bottom
221 drainage. Atmospheric demands are partitioned from reference ET using canopy cover and effective transpiration
222 and evaporation coefficients. Soil evaporation follows a storage-based two-stage reduction (Allen et al., 1998).
223 Root uptake depends on rooted-layer water, local depletion stress and a bounded compensation fraction that
224 redirects unmet demand toward better-supplied rooted layers. Vertical transport uses van Genuchten–Mualem
225 hydraulic functions (Mualem, 1976; van Genuchten, 1980), signed gravity–matric gradients and conservative
226 storage bounds. Relative-arithmetic interface mobility and adaptive internal steps permit wetting and redistribution
227 within 24 daily outer steps. The lower boundary is free drainage with no capillary-rise supply. This explicit layered
228 approximation differs from a full implicit Richards-equation solution. Profile depths follow the supplied inputs,
229 including 2 m for Wuqiao and regional simulations.

230 **2.5. Model parameterization, calibration and evaluation**

231 Phenological coefficients, stage-specific specific leaf area and senescence, initial LAI, stem-reserve coefficients and
232 nutrition modifiers follow the crop parameterization described in Section S2. RUE, leaf allocation and grain-
233 number parameters were estimated from 480 wheat and 433 maize growth and harvest observations across four
234 wheat sites and five maize sites. Whole site-years retain their original partitions, with balanced contributions from
235 variables, sites, site-years and crop cases. Station simulations retain their recorded site and cultivar
236 parameterization; Wuqiao and regional simulations use the shared crop parameters (Table S3). Individual grain
237 masses are fixed at 0.045 g for wheat and 0.300 g for maize (APSIM Initiative, 2026).

238 Eight water-use parameters per crop are fitted to the documented Wuqiao treatments in 2016–2018: the
239 transpiration coefficient, soil evaporation coefficient, readily available water fraction, assimilation water-stress
240 exponent, root-density decay, maximum rooting depth, root water-uptake coefficient and root compensation
241 fraction. Each crop contributes 12 seasonal ET, 12 dry-grain and 12 dry-biomass targets, with three annual W3–W0
242 ET contrasts derived from the same treatment seasons. RUE, leaf allocation and grain-number parameters remain
243 fixed. Bounded least squares combines scaled observation residuals and weak parameter priors; objective weights,
244 bounds and convergence settings are specified in Section S2.4.

245 The fitted water parameters are fixed before comparison with the four 2019 treatment means per crop. Previous
246 inspection of these outcomes makes the test retrospective. Station observations have zero weight in this water fit
247 and assess transfer under unconfirmed complete irrigation histories. Regional strategy selection uses historical

weather responses; the crop-calibration years overlap the 2014–2025 regional comparison period, so those outcomes are conditional scenarios rather than time-independent crop validation. Observed and simulated quantities retain matched sampling windows and grain-moisture bases.

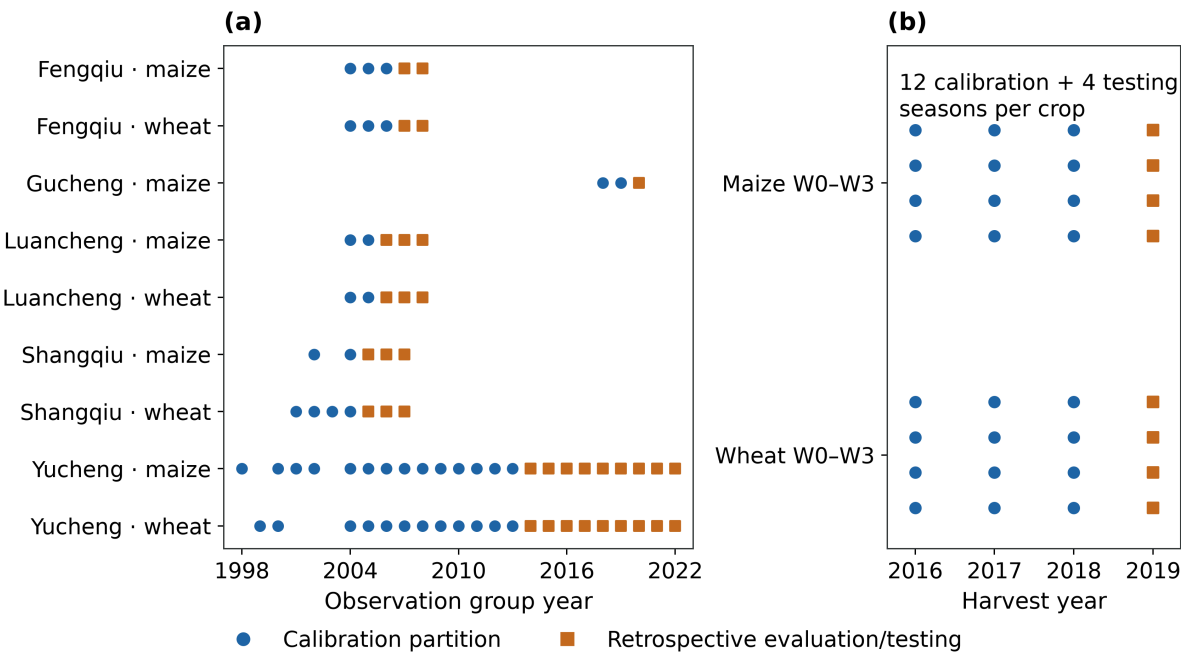


Figure 3. Evidence partitions. (a) Whole station site-years retain their original calibration and retrospective-evaluation partitions; dates denote observation-group years. All five eligible sites are included. (b) Four Wuqiao treatment means per crop-year provide 12 calibration seasons in 2016–2018 and four retrospective testing seasons in 2019. Station comparisons retain earlier growth-fitting history and unconfirmed complete irrigation management.

2.6. Regional upscaling and irrigation scenarios

Thirty-two area-weighted climate–soil representatives were selected from actual source cells using deterministic clustering of latitude, longitude, plant-available water, and 1997–2013 mean precipitation and reference ET. Features were standardized with rotation-area weights. Each cluster uses the actual cell nearest its centroid; the full source-cell mapping and represented areas are retained. Climate years used for policy evaluation do not enter the climate features used for selection. Shared crop parameter sets are transferred regionally without extrapolating site-specific adjustments.

Each representative has five continuous histories at irrigation fractions 0, 0.25, 0.50, 0.75 and 1.00. The conventional wheat schedule is 60 mm at sowing on 12 October, 90 mm on 25 March, 90 mm on 15 April and 60 mm on 10 May, totaling 300 mm. Maize receives 80 mm at sowing on 15 June. These common schedules are declared scenarios and are not observed universal practice across the plain. Every event amount is multiplied by the irrigation fraction, with its timing fixed. Wheat is simulated through 10 June and maize through 5 October;

267 intervening fallows carry the soil state forward. Initial plant-available water is 80% at the start of the 1996 spin-up,
268 with no subsequent seasonal storage reset. All crop and fallow ET, drainage and runoff are included. The final 2025
269 cycle ends on 5 October because the next fallow lies outside the declared endpoint. Nutrition is represented by
270 prescribed fertilized-crop modifiers; nitrogen cycling and spatially varying nutrient limitations are not dynamically
271 simulated.

272 Eight purposively selected non-representative cells provide paired spatial aggregation checks under all five
273 irrigation fractions. Two cells from each latitude quartile have the largest area-times-feature-distance score. Actual-
274 cell weather and profiles use the same continuous model and crop parameters. Their differences from
275 representative-cell predictions measure crop-model aggregation error rather than field-observation accuracy
276 (Supplementary Section S3).

277 **2.7. Irrigation strategies and comparisons**

278 **2.7.1. Spatial allocation under common irrigation budgets**

279 Uniform allocation assigns the same irrigation fraction to every represented hectare. Targeted allocation
280 chooses area shares x_{jk} for representative j and simulated irrigation fraction k by linear programming. The
281 objective maximizes $\sum_j A_j \sum_k x_{jk} \bar{Y}_{jk}$, where $\bar{Y}_{jk}$ is mean annual wheat-plus-maize grain in 1997–2013.
282 Constraints require $\sum_k x_{jk} = 1$, $0 \leq x_{jk} \leq 1$ and $\sum_j A_j \sum_k x_{jk} I_k = (1 - r) \sum_j A_j I_1$, with reductions
283 $r = 0.25, 0.50$ or 0.75 . Within-representative mixtures describe shares of area receiving actual simulated
284 irrigation treatments; crop responses are not interpolated between irrigation fractions. Allocations remain
285 fixed in 2014–2025. Both policies deliver exactly the same total field-irrigation water in every year, so
286 their differences reflect allocation under the same volume constraint.

287 Spatial contrasts at the common 50% irrigation cut use frozen shares of complete continuous irrigation histories.
288 Their area-weighted grain, ET and drainage differences map from 32 representatives to 3,641 source cells. Fixed
289 southern (32–36°N), central (36–38°N) and northern (38–41°N) bands summarize the distribution. Counts of
290 positive annual contrasts describe consistency within the modeled record (Figure 7; Table S9).

291 **2.7.2. Annual quotas based on antecedent water availability**

292 Relative water-availability classes combine two antecedent indicators: regional total-water-storage status and local
293 rainfall before wheat sowing. The storage indicator is the mean of available August and September GRACE
294 observations in the calendar year preceding harvest, with at least one monthly solution required. Precipitation is
295 accumulated from 1 July to 30 September at each simulation unit, covering 92 days before the prescribed 12
296 October wheat sowing. The corresponding precipitation/reference-ET ratio is retained as a diagnostic of climatic
297 water availability. These antecedent indicators do not use rainfall or crop outcomes from the subsequent growing
298 season.

299 Thresholds use 2003–2013 harvest years, the common selection period with antecedent GRACE coverage. The
300 regional storage median is 13.38 mm, and the rotation-area-weighted precipitation median is 431.74 mm. Values
301 below their respective thresholds define lower storage and lower rainfall; values at or above define higher storage
302 and higher rainfall. Crossing the two indicators gives four hydroclimatic classes. The classes describe relative
303 antecedent water availability, rather than absolute water scarcity derived from water demand, allocation rights or
304 access. Spatial differences within a year arise from precipitation; GRACE does not supply independently resolved
305 field-scale storage classes.

306 For each class, five continuous irrigation histories provide paired grain and ET responses relative to conventional
307 irrigation, weighted by rotation area and year. The primary candidate is the lowest fraction retaining at least 95% of
308 class-mean conventional grain in 2003–2013; a 98% target assesses a stricter production criterion. Selected
309 fractions and class thresholds remain frozen in 2014–2025. Higher-storage classes have no evaluation exposure.
310 Required GRACE observations are missing for 2014, 2018 and 2019.

311 Two annual strategies apply the irrigation fractions selected from fixed-fraction responses at grain-retention targets
312 of 95% and 98%. At each simulation unit, the antecedent storage–rainfall class determines the fraction before wheat
313 sowing. This fraction scales all four wheat applications and the subsequent maize application in the same rotation
314 year. Application dates, crop parameters, weather, hydraulic profiles and the free-drainage lower boundary are
315 identical to those in the fixed-fraction experiment. Conventional irrigation applies before 2003 and whenever an
316 eligible storage class is unavailable, including evaluation harvest years 2014, 2018 and 2019.

317 Each strategy is simulated continuously from the 1996 spin-up through 2025. Soil-water states pass between crops
318 and fallows and across annual changes in irrigation fraction. Conventional irrigation supplies the paired continuous
319 reference; replays at two simulation units verify the scenario driver against conventional outputs. Class thresholds
320 and irrigation fractions remain fixed after selection. Outcomes cover all twelve comparison years and, separately,

the nine years with eligible classes. Production retention is the ratio of period-mean regional grain production to its corresponding conventional mean; annual ratios describe variation within the period. The strategies assume access to antecedent observation periods, while release availability of GRACE before sowing remains unverified.

2.7.3. Rainfall-only controls and matched monitoring coverage

Rainfall-only controls use the same 2003–2013 simulation-unit years with eligible GRACE observations, the same rotation-area weights, irrigation candidates and grain-retention targets. Selection groups responses by antecedent rainfall alone and chooses the lowest fraction meeting the relevant target. The rainfall threshold is identical to that in the joint classification. Matched controls receive conventional irrigation whenever the storage–rainfall strategy lacks an eligible class, preserving both the selection cohort and monitoring coverage. Continuous differences between these paired strategies consequently assess the incremental effect of storage-based grouping.

Separate rainfall-available controls apply the selected rainfall-only fractions whenever an eligible rainfall group exists, including years without GRACE coverage. Their complete histories assess the combined effect of rainfall-based management and greater monitoring availability. Irrigation changes in earlier gap years can alter the soil-water state of later crops, so these controls are reported separately from the matched comparison.

2.8. Evaluation metrics, spatial statistics and water accounting

Performance is summarized by RMSE, mean bias error, nRMSE relative to observed mean, Nash–Sutcliffe efficiency (NSE) (Nash and Sutcliffe, 1970) and squared Pearson correlation (R^2). Station scores give equal weight to available sites, site-years within sites, crop cases within site-years and records within cases. Wuqiao treatment means receive equal weights within each crop and partition. Field calibration and retrospective testing remain separate. Grain and harvest biomass in station comparisons are dry matter; Wuqiao grain results retain the published 13% moisture basis, with a single 0.87 conversion between dry and reported grain. Biomass remains dry matter throughout.

Seasonal curves group matching observations and predictions into 15-day wheat and 7-day maize bins at observation-window midpoints in days after sowing. Case means receive equal weight within site-years, site-year means within sites and available sites within bins. Standard errors describe variation among contributing site-year means rather than model uncertainty. Site-specific curves use equal site-year weights. Coverage varies among bins, and gaps remain uninterpolated. Accuracy scores use unbinned records. Yucheng harvest error bars describe quadrat sampling variation within crop-years.

ET sums use identical observed and simulated measurement days within each case and retain the station balancing weights. They exclude unmeasured days and do not represent complete-season observed totals. Regional grain production uses dry mass and rotation-area weights; actual ET includes crops and fallows. Paired policy differences cover 2014–2025. Daily water and carbon residuals and continuity of carried soil-water storage assess numerical conservation. Field irrigation, ET, drainage below 2 m and groundwater storage have distinct accounting boundaries.

Spatial distribution statistics describe targeted-minus-uniform policy contrasts in mean annual combined wheat–maize dry grain and water fluxes over 2014–2025. The 3,641 mapped 0.1° source cells carry outcomes from 32 representative response units. Cell weights are the static 2020 mapped rotation areas after cropland-fraction correction; they represent mapped rotation area rather than observed harvested area. Gains and losses exceed $+10^{-6}$ and fall below -10^{-6} kg ha⁻¹, respectively; contrasts within these bounds are classified as unchanged. Group means use rotation-area weights, regional contributions sum area multiplied by the corresponding contrast, and weighted quantiles use the inverse empirical cumulative area distribution. Annual loss frequencies use the same sign threshold across the 12 years. Connected loss footprints comprise occupied cells sharing a horizontal or vertical grid edge (rook adjacency). The statistics describe the conditional modeled allocation footprint; mapped cells do not provide independent replication or cell-specific validation.

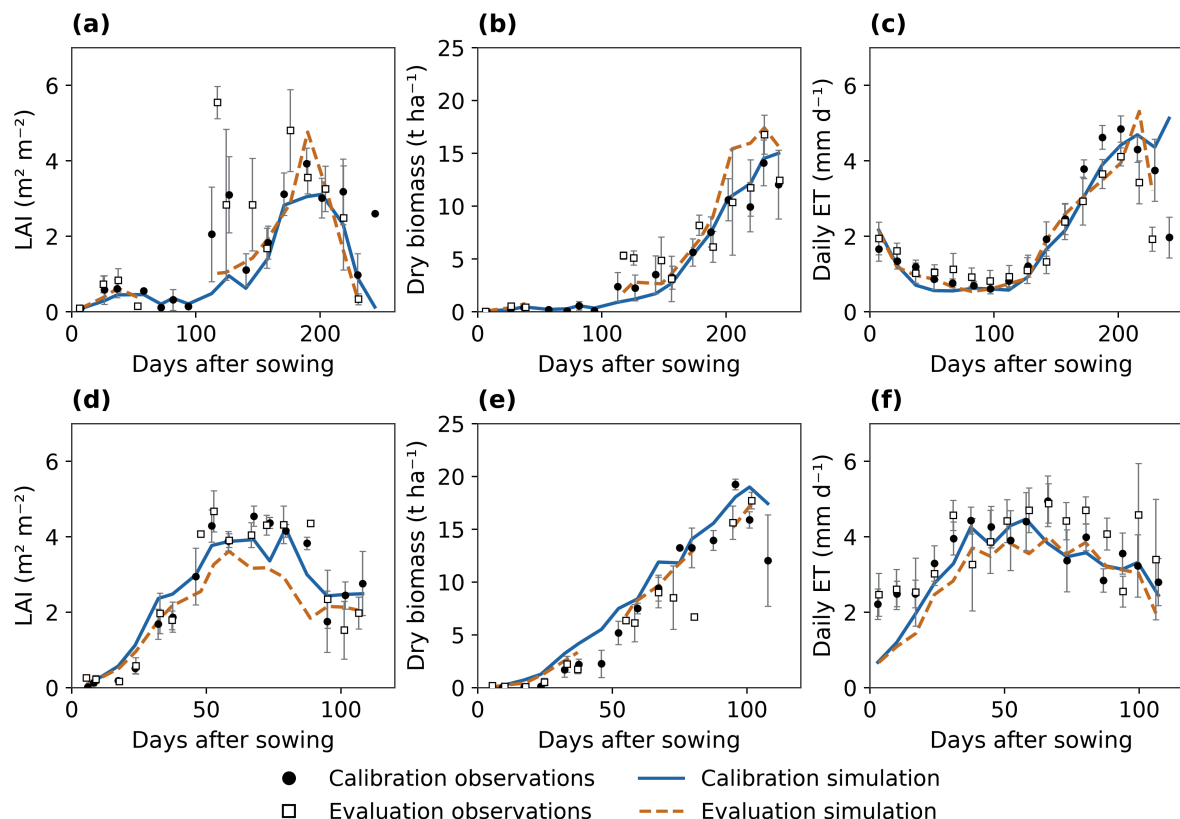
3. Results

3.1. Conditional multisite crop comparisons

Retrospective-evaluation LAI RMSE was 1.843 m² m⁻² for wheat and 0.995 m² m⁻² for maize, with NSE of 0.184 and 0.689, respectively (Figure 4). LAI RMSE in the original calibration partition was 1.727 and 1.138 m² m⁻². In-season biomass RMSE in retrospective evaluation was 4.413 and 2.789 t ha⁻¹, with biases of +1.314 and +1.158 t ha⁻¹ and NSE of 0.349 and 0.796. Site-specific seasonal comparisons retain their available observations and original partitions (Figures S6–S11).

Dry-grain RMSE was 1.256 t ha⁻¹ for wheat and 1.402 t ha⁻¹ for maize in the original calibration partition, compared with 0.834 and 2.286 t ha⁻¹ in retrospective evaluation (Figure S5). Evaluation grain biases were +0.485 and -1.586 t ha⁻¹, and NSE was 0.099 and -1.566. Evaluation harvest-biomass RMSE was 2.736 t ha⁻¹ for wheat and 3.719 t ha⁻¹ for maize; the corresponding observation counts were 54 in nine wheat years and 48 in eight maize years.

377 Daily ET RMSE in retrospective evaluation was 1.809 mm d⁻¹ for wheat and 2.572 mm d⁻¹ for maize, with biases
 378 of +0.141 and -0.734 mm d⁻¹ and NSE of 0.121 and 0.012 (Figure 4). ET summed over matched measurement days
 379 had evaluation RMSE of 51.29 mm for wheat and 74.17 mm for maize, biases of +25.94 and -55.58 mm, and NSE
 380 of 0.826 and 0.118 (Table 2). These sums exclude days without ET measurements.



381 **Figure 4. Multisite seasonal crop comparisons. Wheat and maize occupy the top and bottom rows; columns show LAI, aboveground**
 382 **dry biomass and daily actual ET. Filled and open observations distinguish the original calibration and retrospective-evaluation**
 383 **partitions; solid blue and dashed orange lines show the corresponding simulations. Error bars describe standard errors among site-**
 384 **year means. Balanced means use 15-day wheat and seven-day maize bins, and unobserved bins remain gaps. Accuracy scores use**
 385 **unbinned records. Complete station irrigation management remains unconfirmed.**

386 **Table 2. Conditional station ET sums on matched measurement days.**

Crop	Dataset	Seasons	NSE	RMSE (mm)	MBE (mm)
Maize	Prior calibration partition	11	0.511	45.60	-34.92
Maize	Retrospective evaluation	10	0.118	74.17	-55.58
Wheat	Prior calibration partition	11	-0.300	84.94	-23.53
Wheat	Retrospective evaluation	11	0.826	51.29	25.94

387 Observed and simulated sums use identical measurement days within cases, with balanced site, site-year and case
388 weights. Unmeasured days are excluded. Original calibration partitions retain an earlier growth-fitting history;
389 evaluation is retrospective. Complete irrigation-log matching remains unconfirmed.

390 **3.2. Wuqiao calibration and retrospective testing**

391 Seasonal ET calibration RMSE was 40.19 mm for wheat and 37.44 mm for maize across 12 treatment seasons per
392 crop, with biases of -12.65 and +3.60 mm and nRMSE of 8.97% and 12.69% (Table 3; Figure 5). Across the four
393 2019 testing means per crop, ET RMSE was 73.80 and 55.64 mm, bias was +48.93 and -35.90 mm, nRMSE was
394 21.98% and 14.13%, and NSE was 0.503 and -0.346, respectively.

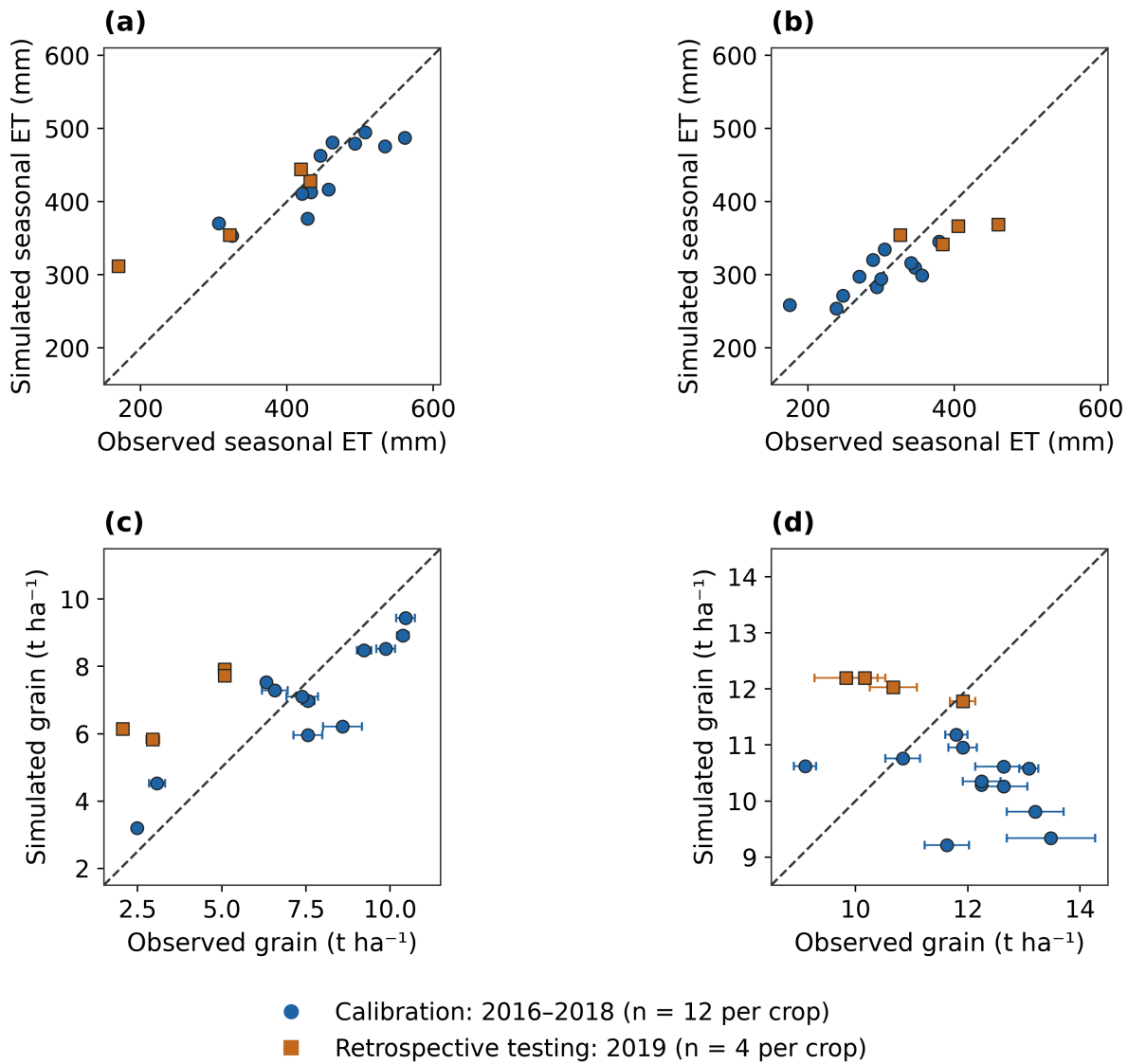
395 At 13% grain moisture, calibration RMSE was 1.249 t ha⁻¹ for wheat and 2.267 t ha⁻¹ for maize; retrospective-
396 testing RMSE was 3.161 and 1.700 t ha⁻¹. Testing grain biases were +3.108 and +1.403 t ha⁻¹, with nRMSE of
397 83.27% and 15.97% and NSE of -4.654 and -3.641 (Table 3; Figure 5). Dry aboveground-biomass RMSE was
398 4.222 and 4.688 t ha⁻¹ in calibration and 5.427 and 2.038 t ha⁻¹ in testing, respectively. Testing biomass nRMSE
399 was 55.66% for wheat and 10.44% for maize.

400 W3-W0 seasonal ET-contrast RMSE was 45.79 mm for wheat and 66.84 mm for maize across three calibration
401 years; the absolute 2019 contrast errors were 116.37 and 52.74 mm. For grain contrasts of W1-W3 relative to same-
402 year W0, calibration RMSE was 0.519 and 1.669 t ha⁻¹ and retrospective-testing RMSE was 1.316 and 1.323 t ha⁻¹,
403 respectively, at 13% moisture (Table S5; Figure S2). Maize treatment labels denote preceding wheat irrigation;
404 maize irrigation was identical within each year.

405 **Table 3. Wuqiao water calibration and retrospective testing.**

Crop	Period	Target	n	Unit	RMSE	MBE	nRMSE (%)	NSE	R ²
Maize	2016–2018	Seasonal ET	12	mm	37.444	3.604	12.69	0.533	0.619
Maize	2016–2018	Grain	12	t ha ⁻¹	2.267	-1.738	18.78	-2.940	0.128
Maize	2016–2018	Biomass	12	t ha ⁻¹	4.688	-4.188	21.79	-5.625	0.073
Maize	2019	Seasonal ET	4	mm	55.637	-35.902	14.13	-0.346	0.343
Maize	2019	Grain	4	t ha ⁻¹	1.700	1.403	15.97	-3.641	0.972
Maize	2019	Biomass	4	t ha ⁻¹	2.038	0.726	10.44	-0.313	0.123
Wheat	2016–2018	Seasonal ET	12	mm	40.188	-12.649	8.97	0.689	0.758
Wheat	2016–2018	Grain	12	t ha ⁻¹	1.249	-0.445	16.74	0.746	0.817
Wheat	2016–2018	Biomass	12	t ha ⁻¹	4.222	-2.480	25.48	0.496	0.781
Wheat	2019	Seasonal ET	4	mm	73.805	48.929	21.98	0.503	0.915
Wheat	2019	Grain	4	t ha ⁻¹	3.161	3.108	83.27	-4.654	0.870
Wheat	2019	Biomass	4	t ha ⁻¹	5.427	4.908	55.66	-0.752	0.924

406 Calibration uses 12 treatment seasons per crop in 2016–2018; retrospective testing uses four in 2019. Counts are
407 treatment means rather than independent replicate seasons. ET is a 0–2 m water-balance estimate under negligible
408 runoff and drainage assumptions. Grain is at 13% moisture and aboveground biomass is dry matter. Annual grain
409 means and SE are digitized from source Supplementary Figure S2. Initial total storage is observed; layer
410 distribution and transferred hydraulics remain conditional.



411 **Figure 5.** Wuqiao calibration and retrospective testing. (a,b) Seasonal ET; (c,d) annual treatment-mean grain at 13% moisture.
 412 **Wheat occupies the left column and maize the right. Circles show 2016–2018 treatments used to fit water-use parameters; squares**
 413 **show 2019, withheld from the fit and selection. Dashed lines denote 1:1 agreement. Crop-specific grain axes focus on their observed**
 414 **ranges. Horizontal grain error bars are the published SE from three field replicates. Observed ET follows the published 0–2 m water**
 415 **balance; simulated dry grain is converted once by division by 0.87. Maize labels retain preceding wheat management with identical**
 416 **maize irrigation within each year.**

417 **3.3. Grain production and water balance under irrigation allocation**

418 At a 50% regional irrigation reduction, targeted allocation gave a simulated annual rotation dry-grain yield of
 419 15.761 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ for wheat and maize combined, compared with 15.029 under uniform cuts. Both yields remained
 420 below the conventional yield of 16.756 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹. Targeting therefore retained 0.732 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ more grain than

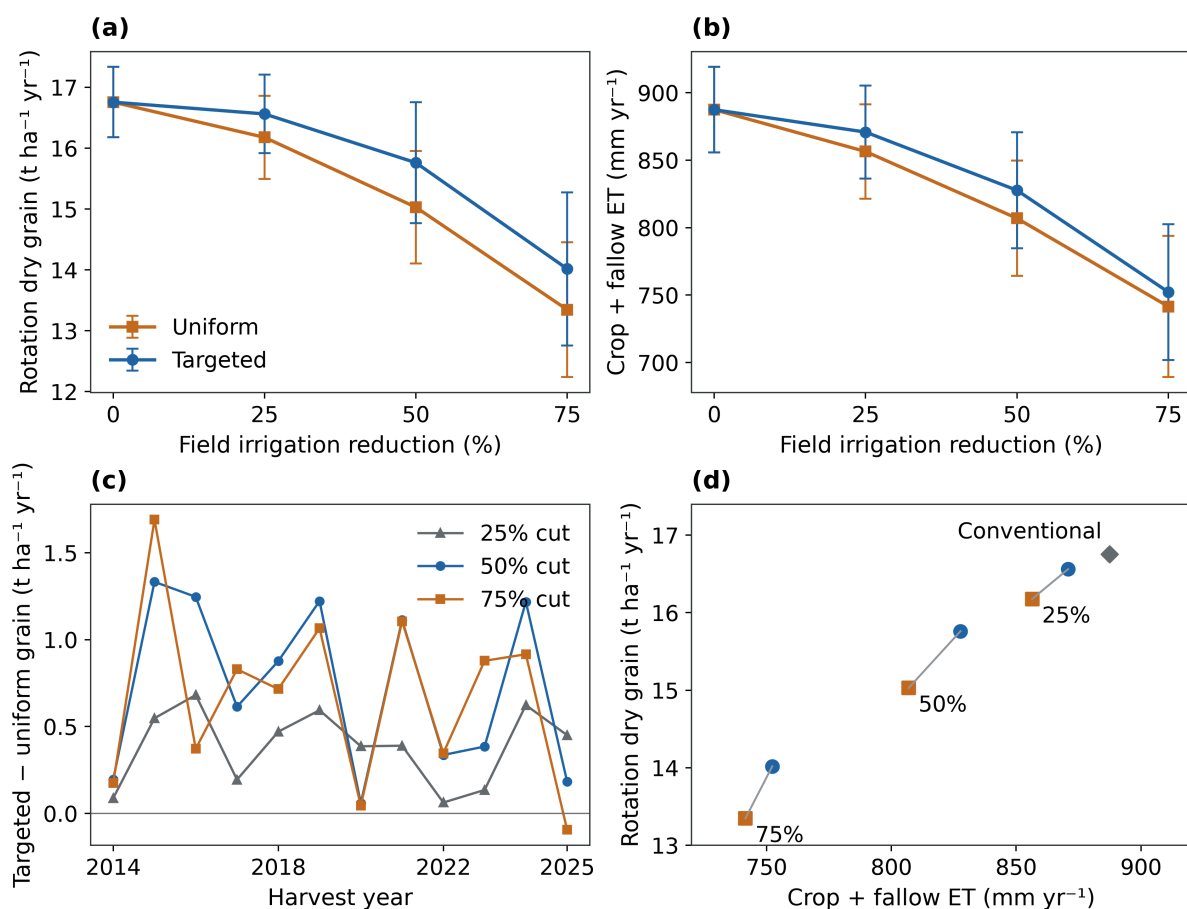
421 uniform allocation (4.87% of uniform production), equivalent to 7.219 million t yr⁻¹ across the fixed 9.867 million
 422 rotation hectares (Table 4; Figure 6). Targeted production remained 9.813 million t yr⁻¹ below conventional
 423 production.

424 Both allocations supplied 190 mm yr⁻¹ of field irrigation. Targeted and uniform crop-plus-fallow ET averaged
 425 827.70 and 806.94 mm yr⁻¹, respectively. The grain advantage was accompanied by 20.76 mm yr⁻¹ (2.048 km³ yr⁻¹)
 426 greater ET. Profile drainage was 79.04 versus 96.34 mm yr⁻¹, and runoff was 14.43 versus 18.99 mm yr⁻¹ (Table 4).
 427 The targeted-minus-uniform grain contrast at the 50% cut was positive in all twelve comparison years (Figure 6c).
 428 The positive regional contrast was accompanied by spatially contrasting yield responses (Section 3.4).

429 **Table 4. Simulated annual rotation production and water balance under equal irrigation reductions, 2014–2025.**

Strategy	Dry grain (t ha ⁻¹ yr ⁻¹)	Irrigation (mm yr ⁻¹)	ET (mm yr ⁻¹)	Drainage (mm yr ⁻¹)	Runoff (mm yr ⁻¹)
Conventional	16.756	380.00	887.43	185.26	39.32
Uniform, 25% cut	16.177	285.00	856.41	135.94	25.71
Targeted, 25% cut	16.562	285.00	870.81	125.90	19.86
Uniform, 50% cut	15.029	190.00	806.94	96.34	18.99
Targeted, 50% cut	15.761	190.00	827.70	79.04	14.43
Uniform, 75% cut	13.347	95.00	741.57	68.72	15.83
Targeted, 75% cut	14.018	95.00	752.30	60.01	13.68

430 All per-hectare means use the same 9.866602 million mapped rotation hectares. Dry grain combines wheat and
 431 maize harvests; ET includes crops and fallows. Regional grain in million tonnes equals rotation yield multiplied by
 432 mapped area in million hectares. Regional water in km³ equals depth in mm multiplied by hectares and 10, divided
 433 by 10⁹. The conventional schedule supplies 300 mm to wheat and 80 mm to maize.



434 **Figure 6. Irrigation allocation and grain–water trade-offs during 2014–2025. (a,b) Rotation-area-weighted annual combined wheat–**
 435 **maize dry grain and crop-plus-fallow ET; error bars are between-year SD. (c) Annual targeted-minus-uniform grain at identical**
 436 **irrigation budgets. (d) Period means; connectors join policies with the same budget. Values per hectare use the same 9.867 million**
 437 **mapped rotation hectares, rather than separate crop areas. Targeting retains more grain than uniform cuts while remaining below**
 438 **conventional production.**

439 3.4. Spatial distribution and persistence of yield contrasts

440 Relative to uniform allocation, the central and northern latitude bands contributed grain gains of 7.475 and 1.886
 441 million $t\ yr^{-1}$, while the southern band contributed a loss of 2.142 million $t\ yr^{-1}$. The southern band occupied 60.7%
 442 of mapped rotation area. Mean rotation-yield contrasts were +2.415, +2.420 and $-0.357\ t\ ha^{-1}\ yr^{-1}$ in the central,
 443 northern and southern bands, respectively (Figure 7; Table S9).

444 At the 50% regional irrigation reduction, targeted allocation increased mean annual combined wheat–maize dry
 445 grain relative to uniform reduction on 43.92% of the mapped rotation area (4.333 Mha), decreased it on 37.60%
 446 (3.710 Mha), and left it unchanged on 18.48% (1.823 Mha). Mean contrasts within the gain and loss areas were

447 +2.439 and -0.903 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹, respectively. Their regional contributions were +10.568 and -3.349 Mt yr⁻¹, giving a
448 net regional grain difference of 7.219 Mt yr⁻¹ (0.732 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ across the full mapped area). Local losses offset
449 31.69% of the gross positive contribution (Figure 7d).

450 The area-weighted median grain contrast was 0.000 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹, and the 10th and 90th percentiles were -1.182 and
451 +3.553 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹. Relative to uniform reduction, mean annual field irrigation increased by 119.0 mm yr⁻¹ in the
452 gain area and decreased by 139.0 mm yr⁻¹ in the loss area. The corresponding crop-plus-fallow ET contrasts were
453 +94.4 and -55.1 mm yr⁻¹. Irrigation changes balanced at regional scale, whereas the area-weighted mean ET
454 contrast was +20.8 mm yr⁻¹.

455 Negative yield contrasts persisted over 2014–2025: 21.34% of the mapped rotation area had lower yields than under
456 uniform allocation in all 12 years, and 37.60% experienced a loss in at least one year. Every response unit with a
457 negative period-mean contrast recorded losses in at least 9 years; all response units with a positive period-mean
458 contrast recorded gains in all 12 years. Across years, the mean annual area exposed to a loss was 35.37%. Mapped
459 cells with negative period-mean contrasts formed 8 connected components under rook adjacency. The largest
460 contained 3.700 Mha of mapped rotation area (99.73% of all loss area), with occupied cell centers extending from
461 32.0 to 36.3°N and 112.8 to 121.5°E.

462 Negative period-mean yield contrasts occupied 32.80%, 37.60%, and 60.08% of mapped rotation area at reductions
463 of 25%, 50%, and 75%, respectively. At the 75% reduction, the area-weighted median contrast became negative
464 (-0.788 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹), although gains on 37.04% of the area produced a positive regional balance. Gross positive and
465 negative contributions at that reduction were +14.100 and -7.487 Mt yr⁻¹, leaving a net gain of 6.614 Mt yr⁻¹, below
466 the net gain at the 50% reduction.

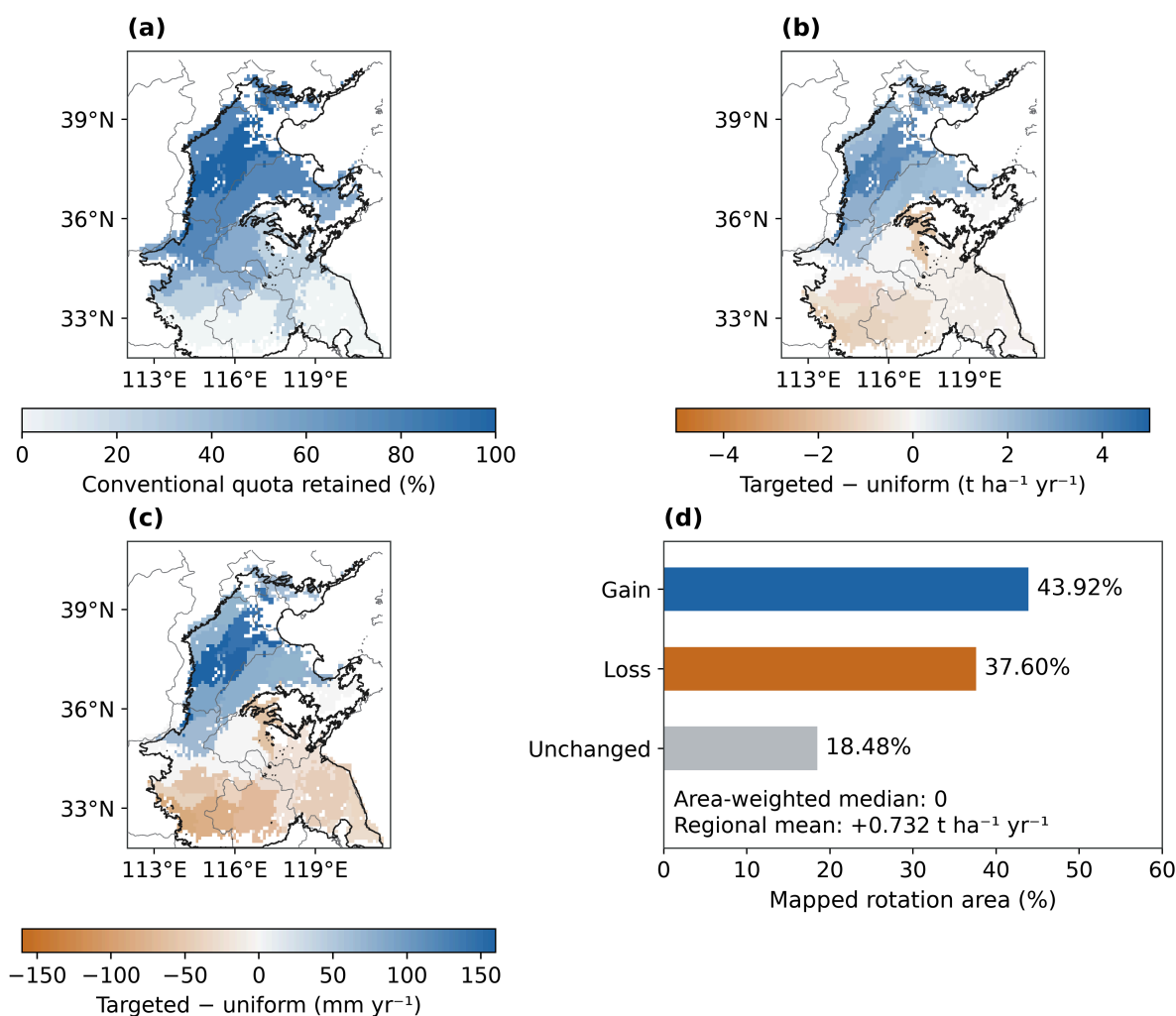


Figure 7. Spatial redistribution at a common 50% regional irrigation reduction, 2014–2025. (a) Targeted fraction of the conventional quota; uniform allocation retains 50% everywhere. (b,c) Targeted-minus-uniform combined rotation dry grain and crop-plus-fallow ET. (d) Mapped rotation-area shares with positive, negative or unchanged mean grain contrasts. The 3,641 cells inherit 32 representative responses. Thin grey provincial lines and black study-domain outlines follow Figure 2; unmapped areas remain blank.

3.5. Antecedent water availability and annual irrigation strategies

Four antecedent storage–rainfall classes occurred during 2003–2013. Nine comparison years had eligible GRACE observations, all in the lower-storage category; three years without eligible GRACE observations received conventional irrigation quotas. At the 95% grain target, both storage strata selected an irrigation fraction of 0.75 under lower rainfall and 0.50 under higher rainfall. The 98% target selected 1.00 and 0.75, respectively (Table 5). Continuous strategies selected at the 95% and 98% targets retained 96.27% and 99.63% of conventional grain production over the nine years with eligible GRACE observations. Field-irrigation reductions were 130.72 and 35.72 mm per rotation; corresponding ET reductions were 36.84 and 6.17 mm (Figure 8; Table S7). The 95% strategy retained at least 95% in 8 of nine years, with a minimum of 92.12%.

Storage–rainfall and matched rainfall-only strategies selected identical irrigation fractions and produced identical grain, ET, drainage and irrigation histories at both targets. Rainfall-only strategies that applied decisions during GRACE gaps followed different irrigation histories and carried different soil-water states into subsequent crops (Table S8).

Table 5. Selected irrigation candidates by relative water-availability class.

Class	Irrigation fraction	Wheat irrigation (mm)	Maize irrigation (mm)	Selection grain retention (%)
Higher storage dry	0.750	225.000	60.000	95.537
Higher storage wet	0.500	150.000	40.000	97.093
Lower storage dry	0.750	225.000	60.000	96.617
Lower storage wet	0.500	150.000	40.000	97.431

Fractions meet the 95% class-mean grain target during selection years 2003–2013. Current shared crop parameters apply throughout. Both storage strata select identical fractions within each rainfall group; higher-storage classes have no later-period exposure.

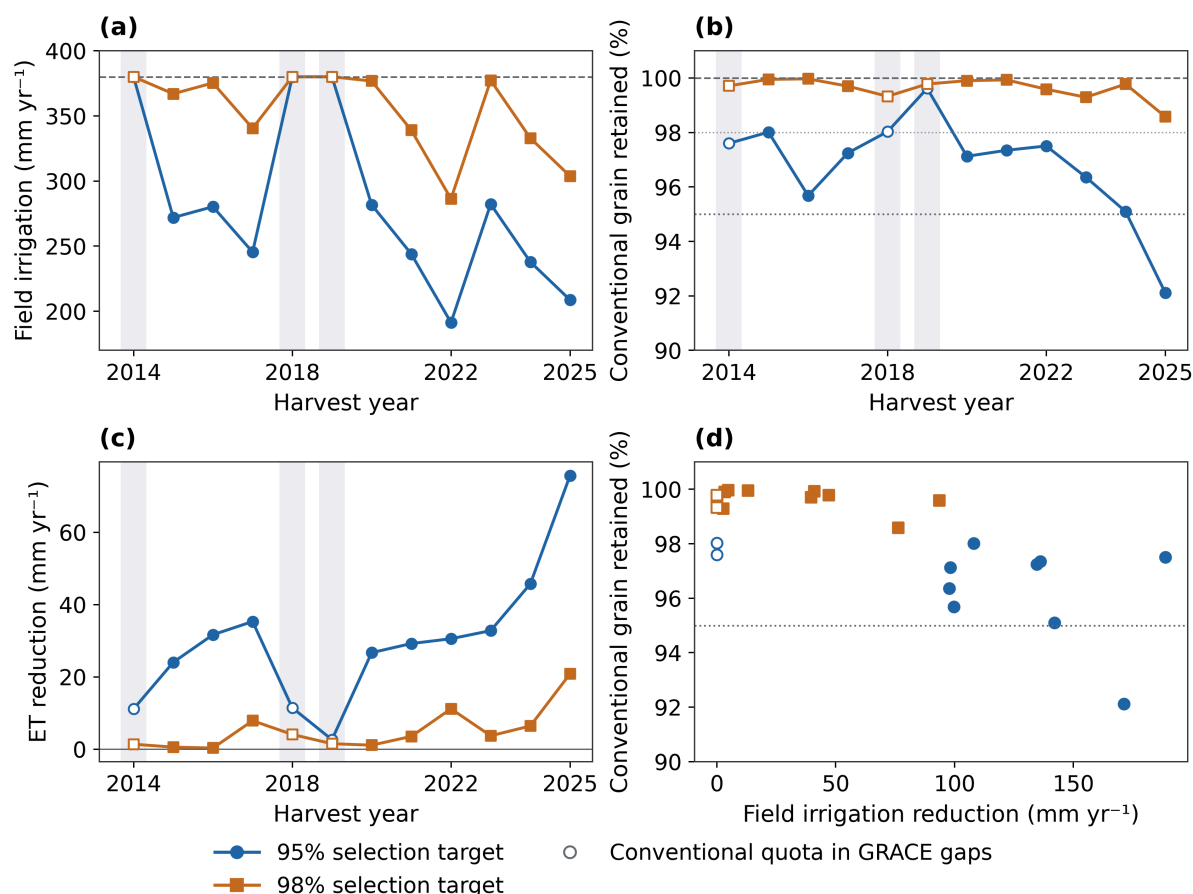


Figure 8. Continuous annual irrigation strategies during 2014–2025. (a) Field irrigation; (b) grain retained relative to conventional irrigation; (c) crop-plus-fallow ET reduction; (d) annual production–irrigation combinations. Blue circles and orange squares identify 95% and 98% selection targets. Shading and open markers identify missing-GRACE years with conventional quotas. Grain and ET can still differ in those years because preceding strategy decisions alter carried soil-water states. Matched rainfall-only histories coincide with the storage–rainfall histories.

4. Discussion

The simulations reveal three linked dimensions of irrigation management: production retained under a delivery constraint, consumptive water use and the distribution of production changes. Spatial targeting improves regional grain production by assigning a fixed budget to more responsive crop–soil–climate systems. Annual rainfall–storage strategies instead change the delivered quota in response to antecedent conditions. Both decisions operate through crop stress and the soil water carried between wheat, maize and fallow periods. Their management value consequently depends on the complete rotation response, the accounting boundary used to define a water saving and the reliability of the crop responses underlying selection.

4.1. Marginal irrigation returns and spatial allocation

Spatial targeting exploits differences in marginal grain response to irrigation. Diminishing production gains across field schedules (Yang et al., 2022) and spatial variation in irrigation requirements (Wu et al., 2019) provide a basis for redistributing a limited supply, consistent with regional allocation studies (Jiang et al., 2016). The equal-budget comparison attributes the simulated production difference to delivery allocation. Complete continuous histories retain the effects of earlier irrigation and rainfall on subsequent crop responses.

At the 50% delivery reduction, targeting retained $0.732 \text{ t ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ more combined wheat–maize dry grain than uniform cuts. Across 9.8666 million rotation hectares, the corresponding reduction in grain loss was 7.219 million t yr^{-1} , or 4.87% of the uniform total. Targeted production remained below conventional production. The positive contrast in all twelve years indicates consistent regional gains within the simulated record. Its magnitude remains dependent on the crop-response functions and declared management schedules (Table 4; Figure 6).

The spatial distribution sharpens this distinction between regional and local outcomes. Relative to uniform allocation, mean losses occupy 37.60% of mapped rotation area, and losses persist in every comparison year on 21.34%. Gross gains of $10.568 \text{ Mt yr}^{-1}$ are partly offset by losses of 3.349 Mt yr^{-1} ; the area-weighted median is zero despite a positive regional mean. The regional grain objective balances gains and losses among locations. Local production floors constitute an additional allocation constraint.

Regional gain has a pronounced distributional cost. Central and northern band-mean rotation yields increased by 2.415 and $2.420 \text{ t ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$, while the southern mean decreased by $0.357 \text{ t ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$. The southern band covers 60.7% of the rotation area, so its losses substantially offset gains elsewhere (Figure 7; Table S9). The production objective maximizes the area-weighted regional total and supplies no minimum yield for an individual location. Local production floors and constraints on the distribution of irrigation reductions are therefore separate requirements for allocation that protects affected farms.

4.2. Rotation carry-over and the timing of water supply

The spatial production response integrates water effects across both crops. Wheat irrigation can support canopy growth and grain formation, replenish water available to maize or increase drainage. Reduced wheat delivery can increase subsequent dependence on summer rainfall, producing different annual grain responses under different rainfall sequences. The sixteen-year irrigation experiment shows diminishing production gains, and the Wuqiao experiment links precipitation conditions with wheat scheduling and subsequent maize production (Yang et al., 2024; Yang et al., 2022). These coupled responses make the complete rotation the relevant unit for irrigation allocation.

531 Continuous soil-water histories preserve the delayed benefits and costs of allocation and annual quota changes
532 (Figure S3). Production can be maintained by drawing down profile storage, with later rainfall or irrigation
533 determining its replenishment. A finite-period delivery reduction can therefore include a contribution from stored
534 soil water. Crop-plus-fallow accounting also captures evaporation and drainage between harvest and sowing. Their
535 inclusion connects apparent production retention with the water remaining for the next crop and the complete
536 rotation water balance.

537 The field evidence constrains only part of this carry-over mechanism. Wuqiao simulations use reported total profile
538 storage with an assumed layer distribution. Wheat crop-start storage follows the pre-sowing simulation, whereas
539 maize is independently initialized from treatment-specific observations. Maize irrigation is identical among
540 treatments within each year, and its treatment labels identify preceding wheat schedules (Yang et al., 2024). Maize
541 comparisons thus evaluate crop responses to the initial state associated with wheat management (Figure 5; Figure
542 S2). Regional carry-over additionally depends on the model's continuous propagation and vertical redistribution of
543 water between crops.

544 **4.3. Production, consumptive use and groundwater accounting**

545 The production benefit of targeting carries a consumptive-use trade-off. At the common 50% delivery reduction,
546 targeting increased ET by $2.048 \text{ km}^3 \text{ yr}^{-1}$ and reduced profile drainage by $1.707 \text{ km}^3 \text{ yr}^{-1}$ relative to uniform
547 allocation. With rainfall and total irrigation held constant, differences in ET are balanced by drainage, runoff and
548 soil-storage change (Table 4). A shared delivery constraint therefore permits different consumptive outcomes.
549 Irrigation productivity and consumptive-water savings require distinct objectives (Grafton et al., 2018; Perry et al.,
550 2009).

551 The soil-profile balance also has a different boundary from the aquifer balance. Drainage below 2 m enters a deeper
552 vadose zone, with storage and transit outside the modeled profile (Wu et al., 2023). Reduced field delivery or
553 profile drainage therefore provides insufficient information to quantify changes in pumping, aquifer recharge or
554 groundwater storage. Production and ET comparisons can identify agronomic trade-offs, while groundwater
555 outcomes require the corresponding subsurface and abstraction accounting.

556 GRACE offers regional storage context at a broader scale. Its anomalies integrate groundwater with other terrestrial
557 stores, and its effective observation scale exceeds the displayed grid resolution (Save et al., 2016; Scanlon et al.,
558 2016). Recent aquifer recovery reflects water transfers, abstraction management and hydroclimatic conditions

559 (Long et al., 2025; Xu et al., 2026). The crop-model scenarios quantify changes in field delivery, consumption and
560 profile outflow without attributing those observed storage changes to individual irrigation strategies.

561 **4.4. When storage information changes an irrigation decision**

562 A storage indicator adds decision value when its inclusion changes the selected action or improves the grain–water
563 outcome under common constraints. GRACE represents regional storage conditions, while antecedent rainfall
564 describes more local water input (Save et al., 2016; Scanlon et al., 2016). Their different physical support motivates
565 joint classification, but decision value also depends on how the resulting classes distinguish among the available
566 irrigation fractions.

567 Both storage strata selected the same fraction for a given rainfall group at the 95% and 98% grain targets. Storage–
568 rainfall and matched rainfall-only strategies consequently produced identical complete histories of irrigation, crop
569 states, grain, ET and drainage. The storage split supplied additional environmental description without changing an
570 irrigation action in this five-level quota design. All nine later years with eligible observations fell in the lower-
571 storage category, so the higher-storage choices also lacked later-period exposure (Table 5; Figure 8). These features
572 delimit the configuration and conditions represented by the equal outcomes.

573 Monitoring coverage must remain distinct from the grouping criterion. Rainfall-available controls can change
574 irrigation during GRACE gaps, and those earlier decisions alter the soil-water state inherited in later years. Their
575 outcomes therefore combine rainfall-based selection with additional years of management. Matched coverage
576 preserves the appropriate comparison for the incremental effect of storage information. Finer quota choices,
577 alternative thresholds and verified release availability would define different decision experiments with their own
578 selection and evaluation requirements.

579 **4.5. Crop-response constraints and management reliability**

580 Management selection depends on the modeled marginal response to water, in addition to absolute grain and canopy
581 agreement. Intercepted-PAR radiation-use efficiency (Kiniry et al., 1989), cohort-specific leaf area and thermal
582 senescence connect canopy development with carbon supply; grain number and fixed individual grain mass
583 constrain the sink. Root uptake and the assimilation stress exponent then determine how water shortage changes
584 production. Variation among wheat-model transpiration formulations demonstrates the sensitivity of water-use
585 predictions to these processes (Cammarano et al., 2016). Water coefficients near their prescribed bounds remain
586 effective empirical estimates whose physiological interpretation and uniqueness are limited.

587 The estimation and evaluation data provide different evidence for these responses. Earlier growth estimates use 480
588 wheat and 433 maize observations across four wheat sites and five maize sites, with whole site-years and balanced
589 site contributions. Incomplete station irrigation histories limit transfer comparisons, and station observations have
590 no weight in the fitted water-response objective. Wuqiao 2016–2018 supplies the documented treatment seasons for
591 that fit. Wuqiao 2019 supplies a single test year with reported total storage, assumed layer distributions and
592 transferred soil hydraulics; prior inspection of its outcomes makes the test retrospective (Figures 3–5). Regional
593 comparison years also overlap crop-fitting years, so regional production differences characterize model scenarios
594 rather than time-forward crop validation.

595 The absolute regional production reference also depends on the prescribed management and crop parameters.
596 Conventional simulations produce 8.065 t ha^{-1} of wheat dry grain and 8.691 t ha^{-1} of maize dry grain per year.
597 These values represent fixed irrigation dates, crop calendars and nutrition modifiers rather than an independently
598 validated regional harvest inventory. The $0.732 \text{ t ha}^{-1} \text{ yr}^{-1}$ allocation advantage depends on the same simulated
599 marginal responses; its regional scaling does not remove field-response uncertainty.

600 Substantial field-test errors constrain confidence in irrigation-response transfer. Wheat grain nRMSE was 83.27%,
601 with a bias of $+3.108 \text{ t ha}^{-1}$ at the published 13% moisture basis; the absolute W3–W0 ET-contrast error was 116.37
602 mm. Maize ET NSE was negative, with an ET-contrast error of 52.74 mm (Table 3; Table S5). These discrepancies
603 affect the response functions used to select regional allocations. Numerical water-balance closure demonstrates
604 conservation but supplies no measure of response accuracy. The eight purposive actual-cell checks address a
605 separate uncertainty, spatial aggregation, and provide no regional field-validation sample. Depth-resolved soil water
606 and complete dated management would better constrain uptake and redistribution; canopy and soil-moisture
607 assimilation also requires treatment of retrieval errors and observation operators (Ines et al., 2013).

608 Production-retention targets introduce a further management distinction between period means and annual
609 reliability. Mean retention of 96.27% and 99.63% coincided with annual minima of 92.12% and 98.58%; the 95%
610 strategy met that threshold in eight of nine class-available years (Figure 8). A mean target consequently supplies no
611 shortfall probability or guarantee for an individual farm. Local production floors, acceptable shortfall frequency and
612 a reserve entering the next crop can complement regional delivery and consumption constraints. Forecast-based
613 irrigation studies illustrate explicit treatment of water-stress risk (Roy et al., 2021). Field scheduling additionally
614 requires current soil-water information, weather forecasts and application timing.

615 **5. Conclusions**

At an identical 50% irrigation reduction, targeted allocation retained 0.732 t ha⁻¹ yr⁻¹ more simulated combined wheat–maize dry grain than uniform cuts during 2014–2025. This reduced regional grain loss by 7.219 million t yr⁻¹ (4.87% of uniform production), while increasing crop-plus-fallow ET by 20.76 mm yr⁻¹ (2.048 km³ yr⁻¹). Relative to uniform allocation, mean grain losses occurred on 37.60% of mapped rotation area and persisted in all twelve years on 21.34%. Regional production retention therefore requires separate consumption and local production constraints.

Annual strategies selected at 95% and 98% grain-retention targets retained 96.27% and 99.63% of conventional production over nine years with eligible GRACE observations. The 95% strategy reduced irrigation by 130.72 mm and ET by 36.84 mm per rotation. Matched rainfall-only controls selected identical quotas and produced identical outcomes, so storage classification provided no additional decision benefit within the tested quota design and monitoring coverage.

Continuous rotation accounting preserves the influence of preceding management on subsequent production and water use. The field-test errors and incomplete station management delimit confidence in transferring the estimated crop responses. Translation of these regional scenarios into irrigation management depends on observed response accuracy, explicit production-risk constraints and field scheduling informed by soil water and forecasts. Groundwater effects additionally require pumping, recharge and deeper subsurface storage beyond the crop-model boundary.

Data and code availability

Model code, frozen calibration and regional inputs, observation subsets and quality exclusions, weather, calibrated parameters, predictions, evaluation metrics and figure-data tables are available at https://github.com/SmartAG-Team/agri_water_management. The repository includes a standalone Open Crop Model package, pinned dependencies, reproduction commands and SHA-256 provenance. Reproduction uses the included inputs without another model checkout or access to the historical workspace. Original datasets retain their provider licences and attribution requirements, documented in the repository source catalogue.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

AI assisted with grammar checking.

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